



BE READY.

Pre-season

Your sessions

Fitness + Prevention & health

Program

Pre-season

Duration

8 weeks

Session

45 to 60 min

Place

Gym

For personal use only, do not share. This program is for people in good health: if you feel pain, have an injury or are in doubt, stop and ask a health professional for advice.

Your goals

Fitness

During a match, players cover about 4 km on average, alternating walking, running, sprints and contacts (Wagner et al., 2014). What makes the difference at the end of a game is the ability to repeat intense efforts and recover quickly between them.

- **Endurance:** the base that lets you recover between actions.
- **Repeated effort capacity:** stringing sprints together without losing speed.
- **Fat loss:** increasing energy expenditure while keeping your performance.
- **General fitness:** lasting a whole match and a whole season.

The golden rules

- **Progressive:** the volume goes up week after week, never all at once.
- **Stick to the paces:** easy = you can talk; steady = a few words; hard = impossible to talk.
- On repeated sprints, stop the set if your speed drops clearly.

Fat loss: training increases energy expenditure, but the result depends mostly on food and sleep. Avoid restrictive diets, which lower performance. For support, see a registered dietitian.

When three durations are given ("12-15-18 min"), they are for levels 1, 2 and 3.

Prevention & health

In handball, the most common injuries affect the ankles, knees, shoulders and the muscles at the back and inside of the thigh. Studies show that many of them can be avoided with simple exercises done regularly: a targeted warm-up roughly halved knee and ankle injuries (Olsen et al., 2005), and a shoulder programme cut shoulder problems by 28 % (Andersson et al., 2017).

- **Injury prevention:** balance, jump landings, knee control.
- **Targeted strengthening:** knees, ankles, shoulders and hamstrings.
- **Mobility and flexibility:** hips, ankles and upper back.
- **Joint stability:** keeping your joints aligned in contacts.

The golden rules

- **Consistency before intensity:** repeating the sessions is what protects you.
- **The perfect movement:** a knee caving inwards on landing is exactly what we correct.
- These exercises should not hurt: discomfort is a signal to ease off.

These exercises prevent injuries, they do not treat them. If you are in pain right now, see a health professional before carrying on.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

How to read your sessions

- Every session is written out in full, in order: do the steps from top to bottom.
- "2-4 × 8": 2 sets at level 1, 3 at level 2, 4 at level 3, of 8 reps. "2-3 × 8": 2 sets at levels 1 and 2, 3 at level 3.
- The number in front of each exercise refers to its illustrated sheet, at the end of this document.
- If you do not know your level, read the guide again, page "Choosing your level".

Weeks 1-2 · Getting started

Get your body used to effort again and learn the movements. Effort 5-6 out of 10.

Fitness: build your endurance base, gently.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

15-20 min

9	Easy run	12-15-18 min	
10	 High knees	4 × 15 m	walk back

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

6	 Single-leg balance (eyes open)	2 × 30 s per leg	15 s
11	 Single-leg landing	2 × 5 per leg	30 s
12	 Calves: slow lowering	2 × 10	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

15-20 min

15	 Circuit training	2-3 rounds	90 s between rounds
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3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

16	 Shoulder external rotation	2 × 12 per arm	30 s
17	 Y-T-W	2 × 8	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
17	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
19	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

15-20 min

9	Easy run	10-12-15 min	
20	15-15 intervals (introduction)	4-5-6 min	

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

21	 90/90 hip mobility	2 × 8 per side	
22	 Ankle mobility at the wall	2 × 10 per side	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

23	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
24	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
16	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Week after week, you can add the optional bonus session:

Session D (bonus, optional) - 20 min

1 WARM-UP

10 min

1		Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2		Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3		Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4		Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5		Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6		Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7		Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8		Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 PREVENTION AND MOBILITY

10 min

5		Plank	2 × 30 s	30 s
13		Side plank	2 × 20 s per side	20 s
14		Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3	60 s
21		90/90 hip mobility	1 × 8 per side	
22		Ankle mobility at the wall	1 × 10 per side	
25		Upper back rotation	1 × 8 per side	

Weeks 3-5 - Building up

Increase the loads gradually. Week 5 is the heaviest. Effort 7-8 out of 10.

Fitness: intervals come in.

Prevention & health: you move on to harder variations.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

15-20 min

20	15-15 intervals	2 × 6-7-8 min	3 min between blocks
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3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

6	 Single-leg balance (eyes closed or on a cushion)	3 × 30 s per leg	15 s
26	 Single-leg squat	2-3 × 8 per leg	45 s
11	 Single-leg landing (sideways)	3 × 5 per leg	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

15-20 min

15	 Circuit training	3-4 rounds	90 s between rounds
27	Handball shuttles	4 × 30 s	30 s

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

28	 External rotation, arm raised	3 × 10 per arm	30 s
29	 Scapular push-ups	2-3 × 10	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
17	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
19	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

15-20 min

9	Easy run	15-18-20 min	
30	30-30 intervals	6-8-10 reps	

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

25	 Upper back rotation	2 × 8 per side	
12	 Calves: slow lowering (on one leg)	3 × 8 per leg	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

23	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
24	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
16	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Weeks 6-7 · Intensity

Less volume, more speed: every rep at maximum quality. Effort 7-8 out of 10.

Fitness: short, repeated efforts, like in a match.

Prevention & health: exercises closer to the game, with a ball and in every direction.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

15-20 min

31	Repeated sprints	2-3 sets	3 min
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3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

11	 Single-leg landing (diagonally)	3 × 5 per leg	30 s
19	 Balance with a ball	3 × 30 s per leg	15 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1		Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2		Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3		Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4		Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5		Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6		Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7		Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8		Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

15-20 min

20		15-15 intervals	2 × 8 min	3 min
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3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

15-20 min

28		External rotation, arm raised	3 × 12 per arm	30 s
29		Scapular push-ups	3 × 10	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18		Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
17		Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
19		Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1	WARM-UP		10-12 min
1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back
2	FITNESS		15-20 min
27	Handball shuttles	6 × 30 s	30 s
9	Easy run (recovery)	10 min	
3	PREVENTION & HEALTH		15-20 min
21	 90/90 hip mobility	2 × 8 per side	
26	 Single-leg squat	3 × 8 per leg	45 s
4	CORE AND PREVENTION		5-8 min
23	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
24	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
16	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s
5	COOL-DOWN		5 min
2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.			

Week 8 - Taper

Repeat sessions A, B and C from weeks 6-7 doing **half the sets**, at the same intensity. You will start the season with your club in top shape.

- **Fitness:** Halve the duration or the number of sets, keep the intensity.
- **Prevention & health:** One set less on each exercise.

The exercises

In the order of the numbers used in your sessions.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

1 Light jog and running drills

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: light jog, then running drills (high knees, butt kicks). Otherwise: drills on the spot or in the gym's open space: 5 minutes of high knees, butt kicks and side shuffles.

Key points: Start slowly, then gradually pick up the pace.



2



Forward lunge with trunk rotation

Take a big step forward, lower into a lunge, then turn your trunk towards the front leg. Come back and switch legs.

Key points: Front knee above the ankle, slow rotation.



3



Walking hip opener

As you walk, lift your knee out to the side as if stepping over a fence, bring it round in front of you at the same height, and put your foot down one step further. Switch legs.

Key points: Upright trunk, big circle with the knee.



4



Glute bridge

On your back, knees bent, feet on the floor, lift your hips until shoulders, hips and knees are in line, then lower.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes at the top, do not arch your lower back. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



5



Plank

On your forearms and toes, body in a straight line from head to heels.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes and abs, breathe normally.

Easier: Knees on the floor.



6 Single-leg balance

On one foot, knee slightly bent, arms relaxed: hold the position without moving. To progress: close your eyes, then stand on a cushion.

Key points: The knee stays over the foot, the pelvis level.



7 Small jump, stable landing

Small jump on the spot, land softly on both feet and hold the position for 2 seconds.

Key points: Land on the balls of your feet, knees bent and in line with your toes: they never cave inwards. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

8 **Progressive accelerations**

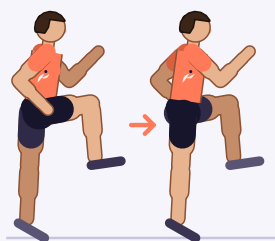
On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: 3 accelerations of 5 seconds, faster each time. Otherwise: 3 accelerations of 10 seconds on an assault bike (air bike) or a rowing machine.

Key points: Relaxed, shoulders loose.

9 **Easy run**

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: continuous running at a pace where you can talk. Otherwise: motorised treadmill, bike or cross-trainer, at the same intensity and for the same time.

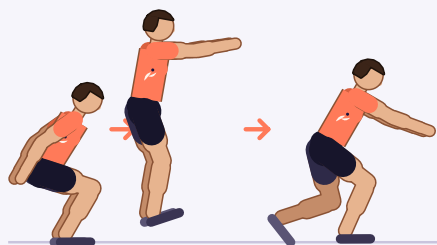
Key points: If you cannot talk, slow down or alternate running and walking.



10 High knees

Over 15 m, drive your knees up quickly as you move forward.

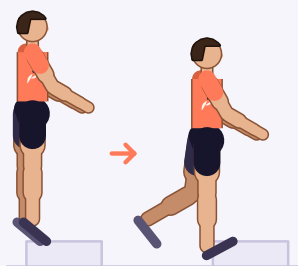
Key points: On the balls of your feet, active arms.



11 Single-leg landing

Small hop forwards (then sideways, then diagonally), land on one leg, hold for 3 seconds.

Key points: Land softly, knee in line with your foot. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.



12 Calves: slow lowering

On the edge of a step platform or a stair, rise onto the balls of both feet, then lower over 3 seconds on one foot. Harder: a dumbbell in your hand.

Key points: The heel goes below the level of the step.

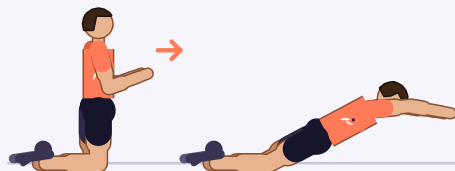


13 Side plank

On your side, on one forearm and the edge of your foot, body in line, hips high.

Key points: The hips do not drop.

Easier: Knees on the floor.



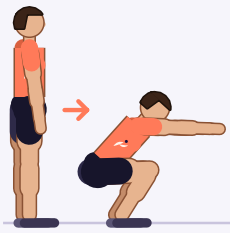
14 Nordic hamstring curl

Kneeling on a mat, feet anchored under a loaded bench, under wall bars or held by another person, lean forward as slowly as possible, body straight. Catch yourself with your hands, then push back up with your hands.

Key points: Hips extended: the body stays straight from the knees to the head.

Easier: Shorter descent.

Squats



Push-ups



Alternating lunges



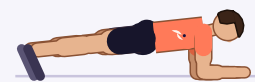
Mountain climbers



Burpees



Plank



15

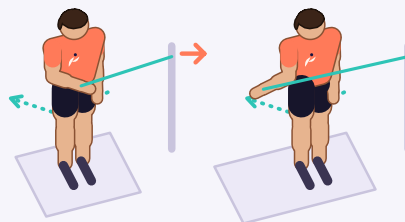


Circuit training

30 seconds of each exercise in a row: squats, push-ups, alternating lunges, mountain climbers, burpees, plank.

Key points: Quality of movement before speed.

Easier: 20 seconds of work, 10 seconds of rest.



16

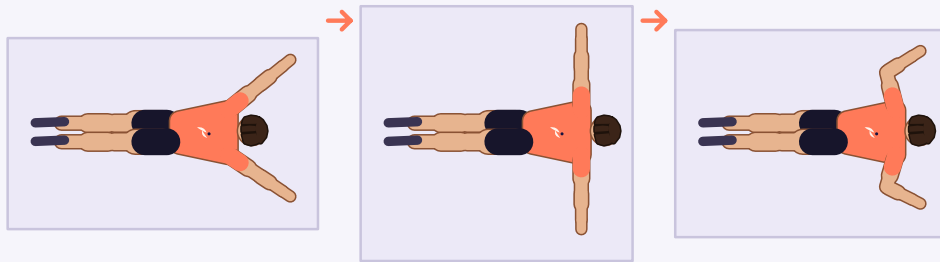


Shoulder external rotation

On a cable set at elbow height (or with a band): elbow tucked in and bent at 90°, move your forearm outwards, then come back slowly.

Key points: The elbow does not move, 2 seconds on the way back.

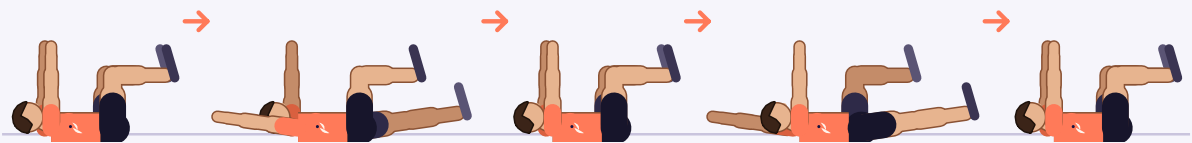
Easier: Without a band.



17 Y-T-W

Lying face down, forehead on a towel. Lift your arms off the floor to draw three letters with your body: Y (arms straight, diagonally above your head), T (arms out to the sides), then W (elbows bent, pulled in close to your ribs). Hold each letter for 2 seconds, squeezing your shoulder blades.

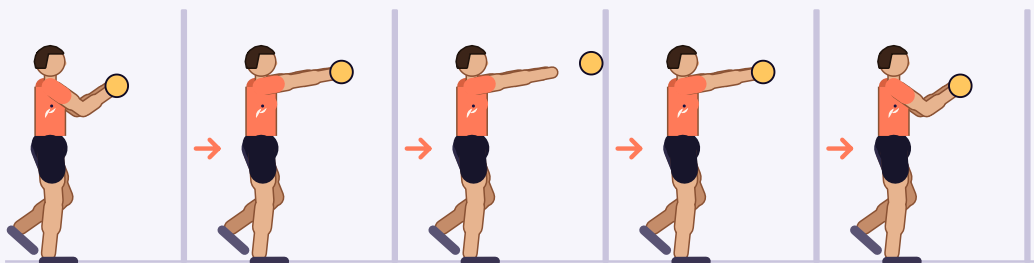
Key points: Thumbs towards the ceiling, no arching.



18 Dead bug

On your back, arms straight up towards the ceiling, knees bent at 90°. Extend one arm and the opposite leg without touching the floor, then switch sides.

Key points: Your lower back stays pressed to the floor.



19 Balance with a ball

On one leg, on a bosu or a wobble board, throw a ball against a wall and catch it.

Key points: The standing knee stays in line.

20 15-15 intervals

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: same work and recovery times. Otherwise: assault bike (air bike) or rowing machine, with the same times.

Key points: Same distance on every rep: pick a finish point.

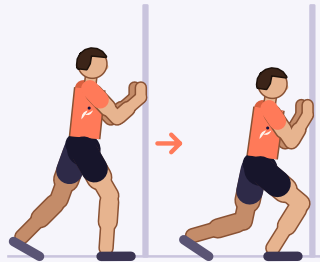
Easier: 15 seconds fast, 30 seconds of recovery.



21 90/90 hip mobility

Seated on the floor, hands on the floor behind you, feet flat and wider than your hips, knees up. Let both knees drop to the same side into the 90/90 position: front leg bent at 90° in front of you, back leg bent at 90° out to the side. Bring the knees back up through the middle and over to the other side, like windscreen wipers.

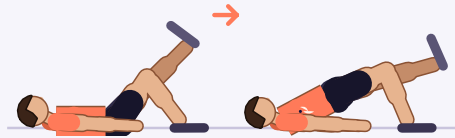
Key points: Upright trunk, slow movement. Only go as far as your hips allow, pain-free.



22 Ankle mobility at the wall

Facing a wall, foot 10 cm away, drive your knee forward to touch the wall without lifting your heel.

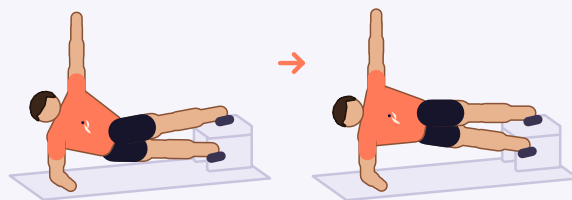
Key points: Heel glued to the floor. Move your foot back if it is easy.



23 Single-leg glute bridge

Like the glute bridge, with one leg straight in the air.

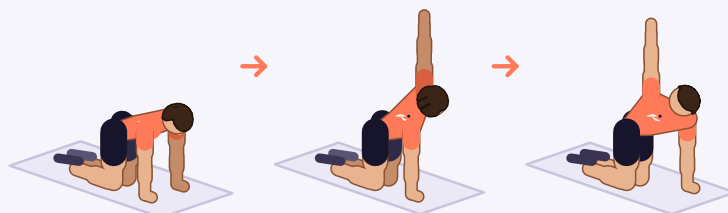
Key points: The pelvis stays level. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



24 Copenhagen plank

On your side, on your forearm, top leg resting on a bench (at the knee, or at the foot to make it harder). Lift your hips and hold the position.

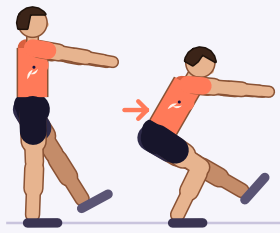
Key points: Body in line: the inside of the top thigh does the work.



25 Upper back rotation

On all fours, hands under your shoulders. Rotate your upper back as you reach one arm towards the ceiling, following your hand with your eyes, then bring it back down and do the same with the other arm.

Key points: The pelvis does not move.



26 Single-leg squat

On one leg, slowly lower into a quarter squat then stand back up.

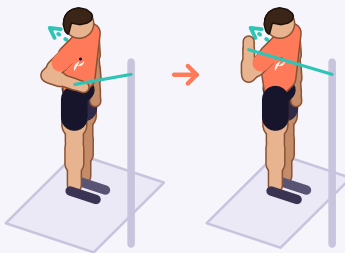
Key points: The knee does not cave inwards.

Easier: With a hand on a wall.

27 Handball shuttles

Back and forth between two lines 10 m apart: forwards, side shuffling and backwards.

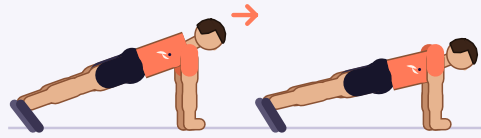
Key points: Stay low in the changes of direction.



28 External rotation, arm raised

On a cable set at shoulder height (or with a band): upper arm horizontal, elbow at 90°, rotate your forearm upwards.

Key points: Slow and controlled, pain-free.



29 Scapular push-ups

In a straight-arm plank, squeeze then spread your shoulder blades without bending your elbows.

Key points: Small movement: only the shoulder blades move.

30 30-30 intervals

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: same work and recovery times. Otherwise: assault bike (air bike) or rowing machine, with the same times.

Key points: Steady pace from one rep to the next.

31 Repeated sprints

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: 6 sprints of 5 seconds, one start every 20 seconds. Otherwise: 6 sprints of 6 seconds on an assault bike, one start every 20 seconds.

Key points: Every sprint flat out.